Safeguarding Policy – Merriott Social Venue

1. Our commitment

Merriott Social Venue (MSV) is committed to keeping children, young people and adults at risk safe when they use, work at or volunteer for the club. We take every concern seriously, and the welfare of a child or vulnerable person comes before the club's convenience or reputation.

This policy applies to our committee members, paid staff, volunteers, hirers and visiting performers or contractors. A **child** is anyone under 18. An **adult at risk** is someone aged 18 or over who has care and support needs and cannot protect themselves from abuse or neglect, including someone who is temporarily vulnerable, for example through heavy drinking or a crisis.

MSV does not run activities specifically for children or adults at risk. This policy covers the usual situations in a social club: families at events, young people on the premises with parents, and vulnerable people among our members and customers.

2. Who is responsible

Safeguarding is the shared responsibility of the whole committee. MSV does not have a single named safeguarding lead. Instead:

- **Any committee member** can receive a concern from staff, volunteers, members or the public, and must act on it using section 4.
- **Staff and volunteers** who have a concern tell a committee member the same day. If they cannot reach one, or the concern is about a committee member, they may go straight to the authorities listed in section 4.
- **The committee** reviews this policy each year and discusses any safeguarding concerns at its next meeting, without naming the people involved unless necessary.
- **Everyone** can contact children's social care, adult social care or the police directly at any time. Nobody needs the club's permission to do so.

3. How we keep people safe

Appointing people. Before anyone starts as staff, a committee member or a regular volunteer, we talk to them about the role, take up a reference where they will work unsupervised, check their identity, ask them to tell us about anything that would make them unsuitable to be around children or vulnerable adults, and give them this policy. We will not appoint anyone known to be barred from working with children or adults at risk.

Code of conduct. Everyone acting for MSV must:

- treat people with respect and never behave in an abusive, discriminatory, sexualised or threatening way;
- avoid being alone with a child where possible, and stay in a visible part of the building if it cannot be avoided;

- never form a private or secret relationship with a child or adult at risk, including through private messages, gifts or favours;
- not take or post photographs of children without the consent of a parent or carer;
- not drink to the point where their judgement is impaired while on duty.

Children and alcohol. Parents and carers stay responsible for their children, who must be accompanied by an adult at all times [if under 16]. We never sell alcohol to anyone under 18 or to an adult who appears to be buying it for them. We use Challenge 25 and accept only valid photo ID such as a passport or photocard driving licence. Check the rules for children on the premises against the conditions of the club's licence.

Vulnerable customers. We do not serve anyone who is drunk. We do not let someone who is very drunk, unwell or frightened leave alone if we are worried about their safety, and we call 999 if there is a risk to life.

Hirers and visitors. Hirers who run events involving children or adults at risk are responsible for supervising them, and are given a copy of this policy as part of the hire agreement.

4. What to do if you have a concern

You do not need proof to raise a concern. If someone is in immediate danger, call **999** first. Otherwise:

1. **Listen and stay calm.** If someone tells you about harm, let them speak in their own words. Do not ask leading questions or confront anyone.
2. **Do not promise secrecy.** Say you must pass it on to people who can help.
3. **Tell a committee member the same day.** That person takes charge of the concern, and brings in a second committee member so that no one handles it alone.
4. **Write it down** within 24 hours: what was seen or said, in the person's own words, with the date, time, place and who was present. Sign and date it.
5. **Refer it.** The committee member decides, with the second committee member, who to contact:
    - a crime or immediate risk: **999**, or **101** if it is not urgent;
    - a concern about a child: Somerset Council children's social care 0300 123 2224 ;
    - a concern about an adult at risk: Somerset Council adult social care 0300 123 2224 ;
    - unsure whether to refer: ring the local authority or the NSPCC helpline on 0808 800 5000 and talk it through without giving identifying details.
6. **Record the decision** and the reasons for it, and tell the person who raised the concern what happened, as far as confidentiality allows.

Anyone who raises a concern in good faith will be supported and will not be treated unfairly for doing so.

5. Concerns about people connected with MSV, confidentiality and records

If a concern is about a staff member, volunteer or committee member, it goes to another committee member who is not involved, or to the Chair if the concern is about someone else. If it is about the Chair, it goes to another committee member. Anyone may also go direct to the local authority or the police. Where a child is involved, the council's Local Authority Designated Officer (LADO) should be asked for advice before anyone speaks to the person concerned. The committee may ask someone to step back

from their role or the premises while a concern is looked into. This is a precaution, not a finding of guilt, and the person will be treated fairly.

Safeguarding information is shared only with those who need it to keep someone safe, and is never discussed in the bar or on social media. Written records are kept securely, separate from ordinary committee papers, by the committee member who handled the concern, and handed to the Chair or Secretary for safekeeping. Committee minutes refer to safeguarding matters without naming individuals.

6. Awareness, review and adoption

MSV cannot fund formal training, so we will make sure everyone knows this policy. New committee members, staff and volunteers read it and sign to say so. Once a year the committee reads it together, along with any free awareness material available from Somerset's safeguarding partnerships or the NSPCC [check what is currently available]. A copy is displayed in the venue and given to every hirer.

The committee reviews this policy every 12 months, and sooner after any safeguarding concern, a change in the law, or a change in what MSV does.

Item	Detail
Adopted by the committee on	14/10/2026
Signed	 Paul Sherwood
Next review due	14/10/2027